

ENG 1005 · Grammar & Mechanics Study Guide

Writing About Mystery and Thriller

Use this guide to prepare for the Sentence Structure, Grammar, and Mechanics Exam. Each section explains a concept, shows a mystery-themed example, points out the mistake students make most often, and gives you a quick test you can use on your own writing. Work through it with a pen — try fixing each "X" sentence yourself before reading the "✓".

A. Independent vs. Subordinate Clauses

- An **independent clause (IC)** expresses a complete thought and can stand alone

as a sentence.

- ✓ *The butler had vanished before midnight.*

- A **subordinate (dependent) clause (SC)** has a subject and verb but cannot

stand alone. It usually begins with a subordinating word such as *because, although, when, if, since, while, after, before, that, which*.

- X *Although the alibi seemed airtight* — leaves you waiting for the rest.

Quick test: Read the clause by itself. If it feels unfinished ("...and then what?"), it's subordinate.

Watch for: words like *when, because, although, since* at the start — they almost always signal a subordinate clause.

B. Sentence Fragments

A **fragment** is a piece of a sentence punctuated as if it were whole. It's usually missing a subject, a verb, or a complete thought.

- X *Hiding in the shadows near the conservatory.* (no subject + verb that make a complete thought)
- ✓ *The killer was hiding in the shadows near the conservatory.*
- X *Because no one had heard the gunshot.* (subordinate clause left alone)
- ✓ *Because no one had heard the gunshot, the body lay undiscovered for hours.*

Quick test: Can the word group stand alone and make complete sense? If not, attach it to a nearby sentence or add what's missing.

Watch for: groups beginning with *-ing* words (*Hiding...*), or with *which, who, because, although* standing alone.

C. Comma Splices & Fused (Run-on) Sentences

Both errors jam two independent clauses together incorrectly.

- **Comma splice (CS):** two complete sentences joined with only a comma.
 - X *The lights went out, no one screamed.*
- **Fused / run-on (FS):** two complete sentences with no punctuation at all.
 - X *The clock struck twelve the body was discovered.*

Five ways to fix either one:

1. Period: *The lights went out. No one screamed.*
2. Semicolon: *The lights went out; no one screamed.*
3. Comma + coordinating conjunction (*and, but, or, so, for, nor, yet*):

The lights went out, but no one screamed.

1. Subordinate one clause: *When the clock struck twelve, the body was discovered.*
2. Rewrite as one idea.

Quick test: If you can put a period where the comma is (or where the gap is) and get two real sentences, you have a splice or run-on — fix it.

D. Commas

The most common comma rules tested:

1. **After an introductory element:**
 - ✓ *After the storm passed, the investigators returned to the cliff house.*
2. **Between items in a series** (include the comma before *and* — the Oxford comma):
 - ✓ *The maid found a torn ticket, a broken watch, and a bloody glove.*
3. **Around non-essential information** (use a pair of commas):
 - ✓ *Agatha Christie, who wrote And Then There Were None, mastered the locked-room puzzle.*
4. **After an introductory Yes/No or a name in direct address:**
 - ✓ *Yes, the safe had been opened from the inside.*
5. **Between coordinate adjectives:**
 - ✓ *The suspect, tall, pale, and nervous, avoided eye contact.*

Watch for: don't drop a comma between subject and verb randomly, and don't forget the *second* comma when information is set off in the middle.

E. Semicolons & Colons

- **Semicolon (;)** joins two **closely related complete sentences**:
 - ✓ *The evidence was overwhelming; the jury deliberated for only an hour.*
 - Also use it before a **conjunctive adverb** (*however, therefore, moreover*)

that joins two sentences: *The first clue was subtle; however, no one noticed it.*

- **Colon (:)** introduces a **list, explanation, or statement** after a complete sentence:

- ✓ *Only three suspects remained: the cook, the chauffeur, and the niece.*
- ✓ *The detective had one rule: never trust a calm witness.*

Quick test: A colon needs a *complete sentence before it*. A semicolon needs a *complete sentence on both sides*.

F. Coordination & Subordination (Combining Sentences)

Combine short, choppy sentences to show how ideas relate.

- **Coordination** links equal ideas with a comma + *and, but, or, so, yet*:
 - *The alarm failed, **so** the intruder slipped inside.*
- **Subordination** makes one idea depend on another using **although, because, when, since, while, which**:

- *Although the window was locked, the intruder still got in.*
- *The letter, **which** arrived on Monday, changed the entire case.*

Tip: choose the connector that fits the meaning — *because* shows cause, *although* shows contrast, *when* shows time.

G. Parallelism

Items in a list or pair should share the **same grammatical form**.

- ✗ *The detective was clever, observant, and acted with caution.*

(two adjectives + a verb phrase — not parallel)

- ✓ *The detective was clever, observant, and cautious.* (three adjectives)
- ✗ *She liked solving puzzles, to question suspects, and the thrill of the chase.*
- ✓ *She liked solving puzzles, questioning suspects, and chasing leads.* (three -ing forms)

With paired connectors (*not only... but also*, *either... or*), keep both halves parallel:

- ✓ *He not only forged the will but also hid the body.*

Quick test: line the items up. Do they all start with the same kind of word (all -ing, all nouns, all adjectives)?

H. Misplaced & Dangling Modifiers

A modifier should sit **next to the word it describes**.

- **Dangling:** the thing being described isn't actually in the sentence.
 - ✗ *Covered in dust, the detective found the old diary.* (the detective is covered in dust?)
 - ✓ *The detective found the old diary, which was covered in dust.*
 - ✗ *Running down the corridor, the lights suddenly went out.*
 - ✓ *As she ran down the corridor, the lights suddenly went out.*
- **Misplaced:** the modifier is in the wrong spot, changing the meaning.
 - ✗ *The witness described the suspect who fled in a trembling voice.*
 - ✓ *In a trembling voice, the witness described the suspect who fled.*
 - ✗ *We almost solved every clue.* (we solved none?)
 - ✓ *We solved almost every clue.*

Quick test: ask "Who or what is doing this action?" Put that word right next to the modifying phrase.

I. Subject-Verb Agreement & Pronoun Case

Agreement — the verb must match the subject:

- *Each, every, everyone, neither, either* are **singular**:
 - ✓ *Each of the suspects **has** an alibi.* ✓ *Everyone must account for **his or her** whereabouts.*
- With *neither... nor* / *either... or*, the verb agrees with the **nearer** subject:
 - ✓ *Neither the maid nor the twins **were** in the room.*
- Collective nouns (*jury, team, committee*) are usually **singular**:
 - ✓ *The jury reached **its** verdict.*

Pronoun case — *I/he/she/we/they* are subjects; *me/him/her/us/them* are objects:

- After a preposition, use the object form:
 - ✓ *Between you and **me**, the butler is lying.*
 - ✓ *The detective handed the file to Watson and **me**.*
 - **Trick:** drop the other person and test it — "handed the file to *me*" (not "to *I*").
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J. Editing a Passage

On the exam you'll fix a paragraph containing several mixed errors. Read it once for meaning, then hunt for each error type in turn:

1. **Comma splices / run-ons** — two sentences fused or comma-joined.
2. **Fragments** — especially groups starting with *which* or *-ing*.
3. **Missing commas** — introductory phrases and series.
4. **Agreement** — *each* / *everyone* with a plural verb.
5. **Dangling modifiers** — an opening phrase with the wrong subject after it.

Strategy: fix one error type per pass. It's easier to catch every comma splice in one read-through than to catch everything at once.

How to study

1. Take the practice exam online: <https://regimurray.github.io/English1005/>
2. Use the **"Review my answers"** button afterward to see what you missed.
3. Come back to the matching section above and re-read the rule.
4. Try writing your *own* mystery-themed sentence for each rule — that's the best

way to make it stick.

Good luck, detectives. 🔍